

ATLANTIC OCEAN



THE ATLANTIC IS THE WORLD'S second biggest ocean, covering about one-fifth of the Earth's surface. It separates the Americas in the west from Europe and Africa in the east. The Arctic Ocean

lies to the north, and Antarctica to the south. There are several seas around the edges of the Atlantic, including the Baltic and the Mediterranean seas in the east, and the Caribbean Sea in the west. The Atlantic contains some of the world's richest fishing grounds, but is also the most polluted ocean because of the industry around its shores.

ATLANTIC OCEAN FACTS

AREA	82,442,000 sq km (31,831,000 sq miles)
AVERAGE DEPTH	3,660 m (12,000 ft)
GREATEST DEPTH	8,648 m (28,372 ft) Puerto Rico Trench
LENGTH	16,000 km (9,900 miles)
GREATEST WIDTH	8,000 km (4,900 miles)

Physical features

The waters of the Atlantic are never still but move in huge belts of water or currents, such as the Gulf Stream, which affect the world's climate. The currents can be as warm as 30°C (86°F) or as cold as -2°C (30°F). Many of the islands in the Atlantic are volcanic and lie on the Mid-Atlantic Ridge. The largest islands are Greenland and Iceland, bordered by the Greenland Sea in the north Atlantic.



Gulf Stream

Although the Scilly Isles lie just off the coast of Britain, in the northern Atlantic, winters there are mild due to the influence of the Gulf Stream. This warm current, which flows at about 9 kmh (5.6 mph), starts in the Caribbean Sea, circles the Gulf of Mexico, and then heads north and east. Winds that blow over it pick up heat and raise the temperature of northern Europe, keeping ports free of ice in the winter.



Mid-Atlantic Ridge

An underwater mountain chain called the Mid-Atlantic Ridge runs down the middle of the Atlantic, where the ocean floor is splitting. Lava oozes up from the seabed and hardens, forming the mountain range. Many of the peaks surface as mid-ocean islands, such as Ascension Island. The ocean is growing wider at a rate of about 4 cm (1.5 in) a year.



Salmon

Fishing

Although Atlantic fish stocks have run low over the past 20 years because of overfishing, salmon fishing is a thriving industry, and salmon hatcheries are increasingly common.